

Of **f**³⁵ MSS that I myself have collated, I hold perfect copies of the family archetype (empirically determined) as follows: 29 for Philemon, 15 for 2 Thessalonians, 9 for Titus, 6 for Galatians, 4 for Ephesians, and at least one for 22 of the 27 NT books (and many more are off by a single letter!). These are MSS from all over the Mediterranean world, and representing five centuries. So what kind of control could produce such an incredible level of perfection—a control exercised in isolated monasteries scattered around the Mediterranean world and during five centuries? We know of no human agency that could do it. If the agency was not human, then it had to be divine. Since von Soden certainly was not thinking of supernatural control, once more he was completely mistaken.

4. Von Soden was obsessed with the adulterous woman passage (John 7:53-8:11) (apparently he thought that it would provide a key for the whole NT). He and his team collated over 900 MSS for those twelve verses (far more than for any other NT passage). He reduced those 900 MSS to seven families, or lines of transmission, that he called **M**^{1,2,3,4,5,6,7} (the **M** being the first letter in ‘adultery’, in Greek). On page 524 he offered a stemma, wherein his **M**¹ was closest to the Source and **M**⁷ the farthest from that Source. The last three families were by far the largest, any one of them being larger than the first four combined; so much so that any two of the three represented a majority of the total. Von Soden argued that his **M**⁷ was a composite based on his **M**⁶ and **M**⁵, and therefore was subsequent and inferior to them.

This is reminiscent of Hort’s treatment of his ‘Syrian’ text. However, Hort produced eight alleged ‘conflations’ within his Syrian text and condemned it for the whole NT on that basis. Now then, a genuine conflation is by definition secondary (if you can prove that the two shorter readings are not independent simplifications of the original longer reading). But in the ‘Pericope’, **M**⁷ does not contain any ‘conflations’, so on what objective basis did von Soden claim that it was based on **M**⁶ and **M**⁵? Within the Pericope there are 32 variant sets that are relevant to the three large groups, that I will now reproduce. I ask the reader to try to analyze the evidence without preconceived notions.

The information offered below is based on Maurice A. Robinson’s complete collation of 1,389 MSS that contain the Pericope, John 7:53 - 8:11.¹ I attempted to establish a profile of readings for each of the three main groups of MSS, **M**^{5,6,7}.

¹ 240 MSS omit the *PA*, 64 of which are based on Theophylact’s commentary. Fourteen